

Auwa Business

*Source: Master Business Plan, March 2026. Updated April 2026 following strategic review.
Maintained as living document.*

REVISION — 5 AUGUST 2026: THE THREE-PILLAR PIVOT

Read this before anything below it. Sections written before this date and not yet reworked are marked, but treat this revision as authoritative wherever they conflict.

What changed. The Kokoro Mirror app is parked. Auwa is no longer a four-pillar lifestyle brand with an app as its Year 1 flagship. It is a **character IP business with a Japan practice attached**: Auwa IS a character and a philosophy, and what it MAKES is the book, the figure and the journal. Everything sold is Auwa-owned, and the growth engine is a collaboration programme built on a blank-canvas Auwa figure.

Why the app went. Tom's reasoning, recorded in his words on 5 Aug 2026: he would not use the app himself in a world where he already has AI; it needs sustained marketing and continuous competitive development to stay strong; it is a different kind of thing from the book and the figure; the revenue is poor even in success (3% of a small free base at £6.99 is a rounding error against Finch at \$30M ARR with a five-year distribution lead); apps are becoming trivial to replicate; and after two decades in the industry it no longer excites him. The More Air case-study argument, which was the app's last remaining justification, is already satisfied by having built it — it does not require release.

The structural point worth preserving: **the app was in the wrong position in the sequence, not wrong in itself**. As the first product it had to win attention for a character nobody knows, which was always going to be brutal. As the fourth thing, behind books people own and a character people love, it becomes easy. Revisit 2027-2028 if and only if the character audience becomes real.

Why the store came forward. Tom is genuinely energised by the Japanese craft side: seeing the objects, meeting the makers, Rieko using her Japanese to build relationships, trips to Japan, tours later. That is goals two and five of the household priority list, and it is the only version of Auwa where the work itself is the reward. **It was chosen on that basis, not on unit**

economics, and that is a legitimate and deliberate call. Judged purely as a revenue line, curated resale would lose to almost anything.

The critical constraint Tom set. He does not want the warehouse. He wants the trips, the makers, the photography and the tours. So there is no store in the inventory sense. Everything Auwa sells is Auwa-owned (books on POD, figures made at home in small drops, prints and paper goods) or is manufactured and held by a collaborator. No pallets, no unit, no customs desk, no third-party stock.

What this rules out permanently, not just for now: the multi-vendor marketplace, buying craftsman stock for resale, and white-labelling other people's goods with Auwa branding. The rung between "article about a maker" and "collab edition with a maker" is a second article, not a branded product.

The honest costs, accepted knowingly. Craftsman relationships stop being a near-term revenue line and become an investment in editorial, collabs and journeys that pays in year two or three; measure the outreach on whether you're welcome back, not on whether anyone says yes to selling. Seasonal Journeys are the only non-passive revenue line and carry Package Travel Regulations exposure (see 6.5). And one Japan trip a year has to carry craftsman relationships, journal photography, journey recon and collab conversations together.

Standing lesson recorded. The previous plan sat in these files for months and every working session optimised inside it rather than questioning it. A decision written into a context file is still a decision, not terrain.

Update 8 July 2026 (decision logged in the finance project's `overview.md`): Auwa gets the household's whole working engine through launch. The planned More Air 2.0 promotion push is deferred to Q1 2027, where the Auwa launch itself becomes More Air's flagship AI-native venture case study; More Air keeps only the weekly warm-network drip until then. A pre-approved £15,000 Year 1 envelope is authorised through More Air Limited (ceiling not target; the decision gates in sections 8 and 6.2 still govern), covering: the Madrid Protocol filing for Japan, US and EU, to be filed before the six-month priority window from the 16 April 2026 UK filings closes in mid-October (priority order if trimming: Japan first, then US, then EU, classes matched to the actual revenue lines); the figure production run and materials; book printing (POD first, offset against pre-orders); and the £2k Year 1 paid-social lane on proven content. Production spend within the envelope needs no further per-item approval. The two quality bets money cannot buy remain the priorities: the app's writing quality and the launch moment.

1. Executive Summary

Auwa is influenced by the ancient Japanese belief that a life force resides in all things. Mountains, rivers, handmade objects, animals, other people, and your own emotions: everything carries an essence worth noticing. The Japanese call this quality Kokoro (心): heart, soul, spirit. When you use something with care, over years and decades, it accumulates a kind of soul. In a culture of speed, distraction, and disposability, Auwa builds awareness: of how you feel, of the objects you live with, of the world you move through, and of your connection to the people and nature around you.

Where Western wellness centres on the self, Auwa draws from Japanese collectivist philosophy. Awareness isn't just inward. It extends outward: to the craftsman who spent decades mastering a single knife, to the micro-season shifting outside your window, to the stranger whose day you can change by paying attention. This is the philosophical foundation that connects everything Auwa does.

The thesis: In an age of acceleration and artificial intelligence, awareness is the human skill that matters most. The answers already exist in what previous generations practised and what modern life left behind. Japanese philosophy preserved them: the 72 micro-seasons, the craftsman traditions, the daily gratitude for all living things. Auwa brings these forward. With better awareness you make better choices, about what you consume, how you treat your environment, how you relate to others, and how you understand yourself.

The shape in one line (Aug 2026): Auwa is an illustrated world from Japan, sold as objects and told through Japan.

What Auwa makes. Auwa is a character and a philosophy; these are the three things it makes. Not pillars, not doors, not ways in — the counting was dropped on 5 Aug 2026 because every "N ways in" framing breaks the moment the product line changes, and Auwa recounted three times in four months.

1. **The Book** (auwa.life/book) — The illustrated story universe and the canonical home of the character. Created over a decade by Rieko Maeda (artist name Eko), grounded in Japanese philosophy. Books 1 and 2 finished, releasing as a set. This is the foundation everything else rests on.
2. **Auwa Store** (auwa.life/store) — A clean shelf of Auwa-owned goods (books, hand-finished figure editions, prints, paper goods) plus **collaboration editions**: a blank-canvas Auwa interpreted by artists and Japanese craftsmen, where the collaborator manufactures and holds stock.

3. **Auwa Journal** (auwa.life/journal) — Editorial from Japan. Craftsman profiles, places, travel, seasonal living. Photography-led and long-form, and since August 2026 its primary job is being the calling card used to approach Japanese makers.

These are not three separate products; they are one character expressed three ways. The stories teach philosophical awareness (seeing Kokoro in all things through narrative), the objects cultivate material awareness (and in the collab editions, literally enact the light-shower mechanic: the maker's work is the reveal), and the journal builds cultural awareness (Japan through a philosophical lens, not a tourist one).

Structural precedents (revised Aug 2026): Moomin (illustrated character IP → books → licensed goods → craft collaborations → shops and cafés; now far bigger in Japan than in Finland — the endgame shape). Bearbrick / Medicom (a deliberately simple blank figure as a platform for 25 years of artist and brand collaboration). Karel Capek (Tokyo illustrator Utako Yamada's own children's-book world extended into six tea shops and a Sanrio licence). Niwaki (Jake and Keiko Hobson, husband and wife, ~20 years from one imported product to a Marylebone shop; own-brand plus Japanese-made goods, a book as the authority layer, editorial from real Japan trips — the operating model). Mjölke (curated craft plus own commissioned collections and a gallery programme — the commissioner model). Plus Kinfolk and Monocle for editorial-into-retail, Hodinkee for the craft-appreciation thesis, and Snow Peak for exporting a Japanese lifestyle philosophy. See `competitors.md` for the full analysis.

The pattern those precedents show: businesses where character IP leads and goods follow are more valuable and more passive; businesses where goods lead stay small and hands-on. Auwa sequences character first, commissioned goods second, curated goods never.

Opportunity in one sentence: Auwa is the first brand to join an illustrated character universe with a decade of story behind it, authored by a Japanese creator, to the living tradition of Japanese craft — a join that Pokémon × Kogei proved the Japanese craft establishment will take seriously, and that nobody has built a standing brand on.

2. The Brand Philosophy

Since ancient times, the Japanese have believed that a life force resides in all things. Mountains, rivers, trees, animals, handmade objects, and even fleeting emotions: everything carries an essence worth noticing. There is no divide between the sacred and the ordinary, between thinking and feeling. Everything in the universe is interconnected. This worldview is expressed in concepts like Yaoyorozu no Kami (八百万の神, the "countless spirits" that populate the world)

and in the folk belief that objects used with care, over years and decades, accumulate a kind of soul.

Auwa is influenced by this philosophy. Not as a marketing angle, but as a lived worldview: one that Auwa's creator grew up with in Kansai and that underpins a decade of her creative work. Auwa uses the word Kokoro (心) as its own expression of this idea. Where English divides inner life into heart, mind, soul, and spirit, Kokoro holds them as a single, holistic whole: emotion, thought, and essence unified without division. It is the quality you sense in a handmade bowl, in a well-worn knife, in a season you almost didn't notice, in your own emotions when you stop long enough to feel them.

What This Philosophy Means in Practice

At the brand level, it means awareness. Awareness that the knife on your counter was made by hands that spent forty years perfecting a single craft. Awareness that the season outside your window shifted five days ago and you didn't notice. Awareness that the person sitting next to you on the train is carrying something heavy. Awareness that your own emotions, even the difficult ones, carry meaning and deserve to be witnessed rather than fixed.

This is the opposite of the Western wellness model, which centres on the self. Japanese collectivist philosophy starts from connection: you are not the centre, you are part of a whole. The reason Japan's streets are clean, its temples preserved, its service culture extraordinary is not rules. It's awareness. Awareness of others. Awareness of shared space. Awareness that your actions ripple outward.

In an era where efficiency and economics became the top priority, much of this was lost. But as Matsuba Tomi, who runs a folk house inn in Japan, puts it: "If we reexamine the inefficient, the values of the past, we can have a better way of life." Auwa exists to do exactly that: to bring forward what Japanese philosophy preserved, and to show that even if you can't live this way all the time, it can be a model, informing the choices you make and slowly changing things for the better.

Today, with record tourism (42.7M visitors in 2025), Japan is experiencing the tension of this philosophy colliding with cultures that lack it. Auwa doesn't lecture about this. It builds the awareness that makes lectures unnecessary. When you sense the life force in a 400-year-old temple, you don't need a sign telling you not to vandalise it. When you see the person next to you as connected to you, you behave differently. This is gentle education through philosophy, not rules.

When you see the Kokoro in a ceramic cup, a forest, a stranger's face, your own sadness, you make more conscious choices. About what you consume. How you travel. How you treat your environment. How you relate to others.

How the Philosophy Powers Each Pillar

The Story teaches philosophical awareness. A series of illustrated stories show the Auwa character revealing the Kokoro in a flower, a coral, a displaced tanuki, a human. The narrative makes the abstract philosophy concrete and felt — the best way to understand Yaoyorozu no Kami is to see it embodied in story.

The Store cultivates material awareness. Every object exists because someone poured their Kokoro into making it: Rieko into the figure, a maker into a collab edition. Owning a hand-finished object rather than a mass-produced one is a conscious act — intention over convenience, craft over disposability, Kokoro over commodity.

The collaboration editions go further, and this is the piece that makes the whole brand cohere. **A blank Auwa arrives without its reveal; the maker's hands are what reveal it.** The object performs the exact mechanic of the books, which means the character and the craft are the same subject rather than an asserted connection. It also inverts the usual licensing relationship: Auwa is not putting a logo on a craftsman's work, it is offering a form on which the craftsman's own Kokoro becomes visible. This was Rieko's idea and it is the strongest product concept in the plan.

The Journal builds cultural awareness. Travel stories, craftsman profiles, and seasonal essays that share Japan through Auwa's philosophical lens — written by Tom and Rieko from over 15 years of travelling Japan together. Not tourist itineraries but atmospheric writing about onsen culture, temple mornings, rural craft towns, the changing seasons. The journal naturally models how to engage with Japan respectfully: with curiosity, patience, and an understanding that you are a guest in someone else's home. Photography-led, contemplative, grounded. Since Aug 2026 it also has a working job: it is the portfolio Rieko sends when she approaches a maker, and the first thing offered to that maker is a story about them, given as a gift, with no commercial ask attached.

(The App built emotional awareness through a daily reflection practice. Parked Aug 2026; spec preserved in `context/pillar/app.md`.)

3. Massive Transformative Purpose, Vision, Mission & Values

MTP: To show the world that a more aware, more intentional life is possible, guided by Japanese philosophy that has practised it for centuries.

Short form (internal): *Restore awareness to a distracted world.* (Robin Sharma)

Vision: A world where people live with deeper awareness: of their emotions, of the objects they share their lives with, of the natural world around them, and of their connection to other people. A world where that awareness leads to a more intentional, purposeful life: what the Japanese call *ikigai*. Real abundance is not material. It is the abundance of the heart.

Mission: To apply Japanese philosophical awareness to modern life, expressed through three interconnected things: an illustrated story universe, objects made and co-made with Japanese hands, and editorial storytelling from Japan, all rooted in the ancient Japanese belief that a life force resides in all things.

Public framing on auwa.life uses "What we make." and never a count. Shipped 5 Aug 2026, going further than the planned "three ways in": the homepage now states what Auwa IS (a character and a philosophy) in the intro and above the product module, and lists what it MAKES below. Don't reintroduce a count in public copy.

Core Values:

- Awareness over autopilot: notice more, consume less, choose better
- Kokoro over commerce: soul precedes sales in every decision
- Connection over individualism: you are part of a whole, not the centre of it
- Depth over surface: history and imperfection carry more beauty than polish. Old things made with care, made with the soul, are the most beautiful
- Respect over consumption: engage with culture, craft, and places as a guest, not a customer
- Authenticity over algorithm: cultural truth and 15+ years of shared experience in Japan are the moat
- Seasonal wisdom over hustle culture: honour cycles, not streaks
- Clarity over clutter

4. The Auwa Name & Origin

The name Auwa (あうわ) derives from Woshite cosmology, one of the oldest streams of Japanese philosophical thought. あ (A) represents the heavens and the unseen, う (U) represents the

connection between worlds, ㍻ (WA) represents the earth and the seen. Auwa means "the harmony between the unseen and the seen" — making the invisible visible.

This etymology encodes what the brand does: making invisible things visible. The app makes invisible emotions visible. The store reveals the invisible craftsmanship within everyday objects. The journal makes the invisible world of Japan visible through atmospheric storytelling. The book makes the invisible Kokoro within all living things visible through illustrated narrative.

Within the book and app, Auwa is also a character — a luminous being who reveals the Kokoro in everything through a magical light shower. The character is the embodiment of the philosophy, not a mascot. It appears only in the stories and the app, making those spaces feel special. The broader brand — the store, the journal, the overall identity — expresses the philosophy through design, editorial, and craft without needing the character. Think of it like Studio Ghibli: deep cosmological philosophy underpins every film, but the marketing is just beautiful imagery and a feeling. The depth is there for those who go looking.

6. Products & Services

6.1 Kokoro Mirror App (auwa.app) — PARKED, 5 August 2026

Status: built, craft-passed, live but unreleased and unmaintained. Not cancelled, not scheduled. Leave it live, don't maintain it, don't release it to friends. Keep the domain and trademark class 9. The full spec is preserved in `context/pillar/app.md` and the build state in `context/app/`. The Yamato emotional framework and its colour system remain owned IP and are reusable in prints and editions outside the app.

Revisit condition, not a date: only if and when the character audience becomes real — a published book with reach, a sold-out figure edition, a mailing list in the thousands. At that point it becomes a companion to a known character rather than a product fighting for attention on its own, which is a completely different proposition and a much easier build.

Reasoning is recorded in full in the REVISION note at the top of this document. The rest of section 6.1 below is retained for reference only and describes a product that is not currently being built.

(Reference: the original 6.1 specification.) A daily awareness practice. Five minutes. The user shares how they feel, Auwa's AI identifies the emotion and reflects it back poetically alongside Rieko's illustrated Auwa character, a light shower animation, and a calligraphic stamp. The

result is saved to a visual archive and optionally journaled and shared. No streaks, no badges, no push notifications. Auwa is pull, not push. **Auwa does not fix. Auwa reveals.**

The Auwa character appears in the app — this is one of the two spaces (alongside the book) where the character lives as a presence, giving the practice warmth and distinctiveness.

Emotional Framework: The app uses a proprietary framework based on Yamato language (ancient Japanese) to identify and reflect nuanced emotional states. Five core states — Hare (晴/Radiant), Takaburi (昂/Intense), Aware (哀/Reflective), Yuragi (揺/Unsettled), and Nagomi (和/Serene) — each containing multiple sub-expressions described through poetic Japanese words. This replaces the earlier Kido Airaku framework with something richer and more nuanced. Users never see the taxonomy; they feel the precision.

The 72 Micro-Seasons: Japan's 72 micro-seasons (Shichijūni-kō) divide the year into five-day periods reflecting subtle natural changes. In the app, they appear as an ambient calligraphic stamp on the revelation screen — atmospheric, tappable for the curious. The AI's reflections do NOT force connections to the current micro-season. The micro-seasons also power the content calendar (72 posts/year, refreshing every 5 days).

Why EQ matters (app-specific evidence):

- Demand for emotional and social skills projected to grow ~26% by 2030
- WEF Future of Jobs Report 2025 identifies EQ among top core skills alongside technological literacy
- Frontiers in Psychology 2025: documented a global decline of nearly 6% in EQ scores between 2019 and 2024
- Capgemini: 83% of organisations say highly emotionally intelligent workforce will be a prerequisite for success

The daily practice of noticing and naming your emotions — the core of the Kokoro Mirror — trains all four pillars of EQ (Salovey & Mayer): perceiving emotions (Kokoro revelation), using emotions (journal reflection), understanding emotions (Kokoro Archive pattern recognition), and managing emotions (the natural result of sustained awareness practice).

User Experience Flow:

1. **Arrival** — Dark, calm screen. Soft glowing orb pulses. "How are you feeling right now?"
Up to 200 words. No signup wall.
2. **Light Shower** — Orb brightens. Aurora-coloured light cascades 3-5 seconds. Subtle atmospheric audio.

3. **Kokoro Revelation** — Gradient background (colour families mapped to emotional states), Auwa character variant (hand-illustrated by Rieko), calligraphic kō stamp. AI-generated poetic reflection below.
4. **Journal Prompt** — Smart pre-population or open prompt. Optional.
5. **Share** — Designed card for Instagram Stories (9:16) and square. Journal entry always private.
6. **Save** — Auto-saved to Kokoro Archive.
7. **Returning Users** — "Auwa remembers you. Your last visit, you carried [emotion]."
8. **Story Unlocks** — 5th revelation: Story 1. 15th: Story 2. And so on.

What the user never sees: Emotional taxonomy, framework names, micro-season names forced into reflections, advice, diagnosis, streaks.

Technical Architecture:

- Pre-designed visual assets (not AI-generated images): character variants, gradient families, calligraphic stamps
- AI generates only text via Claude API
- Claude Haiku 4.5 as default (~~£0.002/revelation~~). ~~Sonnet 4.5 as ceiling (£0.008-0.015/revelation)~~
- Even at Sonnet with 2,000 DAU: £600/month API vs £14,000/month subscription revenue

Data:

- Editorial content (emotions, seasons, lore, stories): Sanity CMS
- User data (accounts, check-ins, journal, archive): Vercel Postgres

Tech Stack: Next.js (TypeScript), Vercel, Sanity CMS, Vercel Postgres, Claude API, Framer Motion, Resend, Stripe

Pricing (Freemium):

- Free: 3 revelations/month
- Paid: £6.99/month or £49.99/year (unlimited revelations, full archive, pattern insights, journal, story unlocks, shareable cards, early figure access)

6.2 Auwa Store (auwa.life/store) — Auwa-owned goods + collab editions

*Revised May 2026 from multi-vendor marketplace to first-party + collab. **Revised again 5 Aug 2026: curated third-party resale removed entirely.** Auwa sells only what it owns,*

plus collab editions the collaborator manufactures and holds. The marketplace concept and the curated-catalogue concept are both retired permanently.

The operating principle Tom set: **no warehouse**. Everything on the shelf is either made by Auwa in small batches at home, printed on demand, or produced and held by a collaborator. No pallets, no unit, no customs desk, no stock of other people's goods.

In the same way Hodinkee proved a digital-age audience would develop deep appreciation for hand-crafted mechanical objects, Auwa bets that AI acceleration makes people more hungry for hand-made artefacts with cultural depth behind them.

What's on the shelf:

- **Books.** Rieko's illustrated stories. Route decision open between a publisher and print-on-demand (IngramSpark) plus a pre-order-funded offset first edition. £28-35 trade, £45-60 signed first edition. See 6.4 and `context/pillar/book.md` — the publisher route now carries more weight than it did.
- **Auwa figures.** Limited-edition collectible figures of the character. **Status (Aug 2026):** Blender model complete; several working prototypes printed at different sizes; bio (non-plastic) filament testing next; then finish, packaging and price. **Packaging concept:** special and Japanese without being expensive to make — balsa wood box, ribbon, eco soft material cradling the figure, hand-written card from Rieko. 12-15cm, £140-180, hand-finished, numbered, signed, never reissued. **First edition revised down to 25-50 units, not 100.** A 12-15cm print plus finishing plus hand-packing is weeks of Tom and Rieko's physical labour before a single unit sells, and "never reissued" makes a small first edition a feature rather than a compromise. Sell out at 30, learn the packaging and shipping, scale edition two.
- **Prints and paper goods.** Selected Rieko illustrations and book scenes as fine art prints, hand-pressed Japanese paper, numbered, £40-80. Plus postcards and a risograph set. **The 72 micro-seasons print set / calendar is the strongest product here:** it is made from work Rieko already produces every five days, it is a natural annual repeat purchase, and it needs no new creative effort. Print-on-demand via a fine-art partner keeps inventory at zero.
- **Collab editions.** The growth engine. Full detail in 6.2a.

Explicitly not on the shelf: curated third-party Japanese craft; white-labelled goods carrying an Auwa logo on someone else's product (low margin, requires stock, dilutes the IP, and makes a character brand read as a gift shop); print-on-demand apparel (mediocre quality next to a hand-finished figure; if apparel ever happens it is one considered piece with a good manufacturer, not

a range). Kokoro prints (the personalised year-end portrait) are retired with the app, since they were generated from app data.

Tech stack (settled 12 Aug 2026). Shopify as the backend, our own front end. The product page is built in Next.js on auwa.life inside the existing design system, using Shopify's Buy Button for phase 1 (one product does not justify managing cart state) behind a small typed commerce interface so the Storefront API can replace it later without a rewrite. No Shopify theme; the shop lives inside the site with header, footer, type, motion and transitions continuing, because someone deciding to spend £150 must not feel they have left the brand. `auwa.store` 301s to auwa.life/store; Shopify's own primary domain is a subdomain of auwa.life so checkout stays on-brand. Full build brief in `context/website/store.md`.

Considered and rejected: Stripe Payment Links (cheapest, but no atomic inventory on a numbered edition, no order screen Rieko can use, no customs paperwork), Big Cartel (genuinely good for artists selling small runs, and the right answer if this were one drop and nothing after it), and WooCommerce (would mean running WordPress alongside Next.js for no benefit). Shopify wins on the next twelve months rather than on this drop: books, prints, the 72-seasons set and collab editions at different price points, plus mixed VAT rates.

Trading entity and VAT (confirmed 12 Aug 2026). All Auwa income flows to **More Air Limited**, which is VAT registered; Auwa Limited stays dormant by choice. So VAT applies from the first sale with no threshold to hide under: **20% on figures, prints and paper goods, zero-rated on printed books, zero-rated on exports outside the UK.** Prices must be set VAT-inclusive — a £150 shelf price nets £125, and netting £150 means pricing at £180. EU/IOSS is an open decision: register with an EU intermediary or the customer meets a courier handling fee on delivery, which is a poor experience on a gift-wrapped object. See `structure.md`.

Selling model. A timed drop, not an always-on product: announce a date, build the list, open, sell out. That is how every art-toy edition works and it is what makes "never reissued" mean something. Made-to-order against paid orders is under consideration, which would flip the cash flow and remove weeks of labour before any revenue; a two to three week lead time on a hand-finished numbered piece is normal.

Distribution. No marketplaces for the first edition — 25-50 units will go to the mailing list and Instagram, and a third-party listing undercuts the "made by us, signed, numbered, direct" story that justifies the price. Later, selected **stockists rather than marketplaces:** a good design shop, a museum shop, Native & Co, the Japan House shop. Those are credibility and the same relationship muscle as the craftsman outreach. Etsy is the wrong register. Books are the exception and should go everywhere.

Figure success metrics: 70%+ sell-through within 4 weeks of a drop. Below 30%, pause and reassess pricing or audience.

6.2a The Collaboration Programme

The concept (Rieko's). A blank-canvas Auwa figure that a collaborator decorates, or produces entirely in their own medium. The collaborator's work is the light shower: the object performs the exact mechanic of the books, so the character and the craft become the same subject rather than an asserted connection. Auwa is not putting a logo on a maker's work; it is offering a form on which the maker's own Kokoro becomes visible.

Precedent. Bearbrick / Medicom built a 25-year business on exactly this: Tatsuhiko Akashi designed a deliberately simple figure in 2001 as a blank canvas, and collaborations with Chanel, KAWS, BAPE, Disney and hundreds of artists made the platform worth more than any single edition. And **Pokémon × Kogei** (National Crafts Museum, Kanazawa, 2023, toured to 2026 including Japan House LA) put twenty of Japan's leading craft artists, including a Living National Treasure metalworker, to work interpreting character IP in lacquer, ceramics, textiles and metal. That exhibition is the rebuttal to the worry that a character must be famous before serious makers will engage: framing does more work than fame.

Two lines with different jobs. Do not judge them on the same terms.

Artist collabs — the commercial line. Frequent, repeatable, cash-generating. Send a blank, get it back painted. Same-audience logic: the collaborator's collectors and Auwa's audience overlap, so the pieces sell. ~£150-400. Deliberately include Japanese artists and illustrators from early on, not only Western ones — an easier yes than a craftsman, the same operational simplicity, and genuine Japanese authorship.

Fin DAC is first, this autumn. Warm (a friend), has already painted a portrait of Rieko and promoted it on his Instagram, already has an Auwa stencil, 96K followers, and Rieko loves his work. He is also actively keen on visible collaboration with and in Japan, partly because he has taken unfair accusations of cultural appropriation for his Asian-subject work. A Japanese-authored programme with a Japanese creator at its centre is therefore a genuinely good offer to him rather than a favour asked — and it may make him a connector rather than a one-off. **His piece produces the photograph that every subsequent collab is pitched with**, which is its real strategic value.

Craft collabs — the prestige line. One or two a year, slow, aimed at authority, editorial and *exhibitability* rather than sell-through. The honest buyer analysis, and it should stay written

down: a knife collector mostly does not want a decorative figure, and an Auwa reader mostly does not know the maker's name, so unit sales are not the return. The return is that this is the only thing making "Japanese" true rather than decorative in the brand; plus press, institutional doors, editorial, and the maker relationships themselves. Structure so the maker manufactures, holds and sells domestically to their own trusting customers, and Auwa takes a small Western allocation. No inventory risk, no unproven-market risk.

The taxonomy: where the collaborator's signature lives determines the format. This is the operating detail Rieko works from.

Signature lives in	Crafts	Format
Surface	lacquer and maki-e, gold leaf, dyeing, sashiko and textiles, painting	True blank-canvas. Supply a blank, they reveal it. Fin DAC sits here.
Form and material	kokeshi, woodturning, ceramics, bamboo, glass, cast metal	Nobody decorates anything. They make the <i>whole</i> Auwa in their medium from Rieko's master form; the hand shows in glaze, grain, throw, firing. Most collabs will land here.
Function	knives, tools, joinery	The blank fails. Either they forge an Auwa in their signature material (the lamination line, hamon, kasumi finish is the signature), or Auwa becomes the subject of a functional piece (a kiridashi with an Auwa terminal). Note a knife is made by several hands: the togishi, handle maker and saya maker are far more reachable than a backordered smith.

Order of approach. Start with crafts whose output is already decorative and already collected, where nobody needs convincing the object is a thing you would own. **Kokeshi first** — it is the Japanese blank-figure tradition: regional schools with distinct forms and painting hands, two centuries of turned, painted, collected wooden figures. Bearbrick, two hundred years early, and a kokeshi maker producing an Auwa is barely a stretch. Then daruma (Gunma painters, already on

Rieko's radar for years), lacquer and maki-e, Kanazawa gold leaf, ceramics, textile. Knives and functional crafts are a year-three conversation if ever, and their better use is editorial: a film of Shigefusa's sons at the forge is magnificent content and needs no product attached.

Kintsugi is explicitly ruled out (Tom's call, 5 Aug 2026).

Production note. A 3D-printed PLA blank will not take glaze, urushi or firing. Collab figures in the form-and-material category are made entirely in Japan from Rieko's master form or 3D file. Auwa's home printer serves only the Auwa-made edition. Two independent production lines, no shared bottleneck.

How to approach, and this matters more than any of the above. You cannot pitch this in words. A written proposal describing a character figure decorated by artisans reads, in Japanese, uncomfortably close to a licensing solicitation, and the default answer is a polite no. Pitch it with a photograph of a finished piece — which is what Fin DAC provides. Rieko writes in Japanese, always. The first approach is never "may we sell your work," it is "may we tell your story": a journal piece and Tom's photography, made as a gift, with full use granted to the maker. Commerce is the second conversation, usually on a second visit. What goes in the parcel: the two printed books, a figure, and a one-page Japanese profile of Auwa and of Rieko as its creator.

Register. Frame it the way the National Crafts Museum framed Pokémon × Kogei: an art commission, a challenge to the maker's skill, one-of-a-kind (一点物) or a small numbered edition, exhibited rather than racked. Being "one of many collaborators on a platform toy" reads as streetwear in London and as merchandise in Kyoto, and merchandise is the wrong register for a serious maker. Same object, entirely different conversation.

Who says yes. Not masters with multi-year waiting lists — there is nothing Auwa can offer them and asking damages the relationship. The realistic yes is the mid-career maker, the successor, the second or third generation with a workshop, a shrinking domestic market and no international audience. To them Auwa offers a Western audience, a beautifully photographed article, a piece they can sell well in their own shop, and a relationship with a Japanese creator who understands their world. Rieko being Kansai-born and writing in Japanese is what unlocks this, not follower count.

The long arc: exhibition. Accumulate enough craft pieces to exhibit. This is the real prize, because it solves the actual bottleneck — the character needs to become known and Auwa has no distribution. "An illustrated character interpreted by twelve Japanese craft masters" is programmable by cultural institutions; "a character brand with a shop" is not. Ladder, lowest rung first: **London Craft Week** (annual, May, open participation, right press and audience — achievable 2028, possibly 2027 if pieces exist), then the Daiwa Anglo-Japanese Foundation and

Japan Foundation London gallery spaces, then an independent design gallery show, then **Japan House as a year four or five destination** approached with a track record of three smaller shows behind it.

Note the correct pitch frame for Japan House: it is funded by the Japanese Ministry of Foreign Affairs and exists to present Japan to a British audience, so it programmes exhibitions *about Japanese culture*, not brand partnerships. Auwa must be the vehicle and the craft and philosophy the subject. Get that inversion wrong and it reads as a brand activation and is declined permanently.

Also note the money: institutional exhibitions typically pay nothing and often cost the exhibitor (production, crating, shipping, insurance, install). Their shop is a separate commercial relationship at conventional consignment or wholesale terms, so 40-50% to them. Treat the whole thing as marketing spend with an exceptional return in press and credibility, not as a revenue line.

And it is grant-fundable. UK-Japan cultural exchange has dedicated funders whose purpose is projects exactly like this: the Daiwa Anglo-Japanese Foundation, the Great Britain Sasakawa Foundation, and the Japan Foundation. Individually these are typically low thousands rather than transformational, and current rounds and terms need checking rather than assuming, but they are non-dilutive, free to apply for, and a held grant is itself a credential when approaching makers and venues. Worth an afternoon once the first two or three craft pieces exist and can be photographed, not before.

Gating, corrected. Follower count is close to the least important thing an institution assesses. What matters: whether the work is culturally sound, who the Japanese author is, whether the objects exist, whether it can be delivered professionally, and whether anyone serious has vouched. A book published by a real publisher and reviewed somewhere is worth more than 50K Instagram followers. Eight to twelve finished craft pieces by named makers are worth more than all of it, because at that point the exhibition already half exists.

6.3 Auwa Journal (auwa.life/journal) - Year 1 Editorial

Long-form editorial content that builds brand authority, drives organic search traffic, and gives the audience a reason to return between app sessions. Photography-led, atmospheric, written in the Auwa voice.

Content types:

- **Travel stories:** Japan through Auwa's lens — not itineraries, but atmospheric essays. Onsen culture, temple mornings, rural craft towns, seasonal landscapes. Tom's

photography (17M+ Unsplash views, published in Condé Nast Traveler, Vogue, Travel + Leisure) provides the visual foundation.

- **Craftsman profiles:** The makers behind the store. Workshop visits, process photography, the philosophy of a lifetime object. Bridges directly to store products.
- **Seasonal essays:** Tied to the 72 micro-seasons content calendar. Short, contemplative pieces on noticing change.
- **Behind the Kokoro:** Rieko's illustration process, Auwa's creative development, the philosophy in practice.

Production workflow: Tom provides photo folders + title + bullet points. Claude writes the article in Auwa's voice. Rieko reviews for cultural accuracy. Future: video content from craftsman visits (ASMR-style making films).

SEO value: Each article targets long-tail keywords the brand naturally owns — Japanese craft, seasonal living, specific artisan traditions. This is the content layer that makes auwa.life discoverable beyond social media.

Its primary job changed in Aug 2026. SEO is now the secondary benefit. The journal's first job is to be **the calling card used to approach Japanese makers:** the thing Rieko sends, the proof that Auwa can tell a maker's story beautifully, and the gift offered in a first approach with no commercial ask attached. Weight the calendar toward craftsman profiles and places over general seasonal essays. Cadence roughly one a month, which is sustainable alongside everything else.

Tech: Sanity CMS. Same Next.js codebase as the main site. Markdown-friendly for fast publishing.

6.4 The Book (auwa.life/book) — the foundation

The canonical home of the Auwa universe and the illustrated stories. Hub linking the pillars. This is where the deeper mythology lives — the WAWA origin, the character's story, the philosophy in narrative form.

Elevated in Aug 2026 from "brand home" to the foundation the business rests on. Everything downstream — the figure, the collabs, the exhibition route, licensing, and any eventual return to the app — depends on the character becoming known. Publishing the books properly is therefore the highest-leverage single act available, and it outranks almost everything else on the list.

Which changes the publisher question. When the app was the flagship, self-publishing was fine because the character only had to serve app users. Now a publisher offers bookshop

distribution, foreign rights and review coverage that cannot be bought at any price, and those are precisely the levers on making a character known. **Try the publisher route properly first**, with Colin Midson's view as the decisive input, with IngramSpark POD as the always-available fallback that can be executed at any time. Do not rush that decision in order to feel decisive. Books 1 and 2 release as a set, which turns "a book" into "a series" and is a materially stronger proposition to a publisher and to press.

The Auwa Universe: Auwa originates from WAWA, a harmonious solar system deep within the Milky Way. When its inhabitants received a mysterious signal from Earth, they channelled energy to form a glowing orb of pure light. From this orb emerged Auwa — a being whose magical light shower reveals the Kokoro within every living creature. Auwa communicates through telepathy: gentle, observant, non-judgmental. This mythology enriches the stories and gives depth to the app, but it lives here — in the book section — not in brand communications. The Monocle reader encounters philosophy and craft; those who go deeper find a cosmic story.

The Series of Illustrated Stories (2015-2025): Created by Rieko Maeda over a decade of development. Never published. Being prepared for digital release as illustrated art stories, with limited-edition physical versions to follow. Released over time within the app as narrative segments unlocked through continued engagement.

1. **The Beginning** — Auwa arrives on Earth, discovers a quiet forest where a lonely blue flower (Bluu) shares memories of a diminished ecosystem. Light shower reveals Kokoro within flower and surrounding microbes.
2. **Umi (Ocean)** — Auwa explores beneath the waves, meeting Key the coral, Lady the fish, and Rai the turtle. Ocean damaged by pollution. Auwa's light restores the sea and leads to the ancient Coral Paradise.
3. **Human** — Auwa encounters Rappon the tanuki (displaced from a changing forest) and Kazu (a human who left city life to live in harmony with nature). Interconnection between human activity, animal displacement, and environmental change.
4. **Lioma** — Auwa takes human Kokoro to Planet Lioma in the WAWA system, where the Maon beings live in harmony through telepathic communication.

Stories originally written in Japanese. Limited-edition physical printed versions in Year 2.

Content also includes: Brand story and Auwa etymology, Yaoyorozu no Kami philosophy, creator bios, links to app, store, and journal.

6.5 Seasonal Journeys (programme, not a pillar — see `arrival.md`)

Small, once-a-year guided Japan experiences for foreigners to meet craftsmen and visit places not otherwise accessible. Five people, four to six days. Constrained to one trip per year by the founders' UK life (dog) and by the quality bar. Tom and Rieko pilot it alone in 2027; no paying customers on the first trip. At £3-4K per person, a single trip generates £15-20K at healthy margin and produces a year's worth of editorial content.

Why this matters more after the Aug 2026 pivot: the journal is *about* hidden experiences, the journey is that experience, and the collab programme's maker relationships are the same relationships that make a journey possible. Rieko can often open both conversations in one Japanese-language email. **The single Japan trip each year should carry craftsman relationships, journal photography, journey route recon and collab conversations together**, rather than being four competing ambitions for the same fortnight.

Two things to settle before taking a deposit.

Regulatory. Selling a package in the UK (accommodation plus activities, with or without flights) almost certainly falls under the **Package Travel and Linked Travel Arrangements Regulations 2018**, which means mandatory insolvency protection for customer money and liability for the whole package including a supplier's failures. Two clean routes through: partner with a licensed tour operator who takes the booking, or sell a guided experience only and have guests book their own rooms and flights. Neither is hard; both need deciding before money is taken, not after. Worth a short conversation with an accountant or travel-trade solicitor when it gets close, plus public liability insurance.

Trademark. The current classes do not cover travel services (class 39). Not urgent and explicitly do not disturb the Madrid filing over it, but flag for whenever "Auwa Journeys" becomes a named commercial product.

Also note: this is the only non-passive revenue line in the whole plan, the one thing requiring both founders present, in person, on a schedule. One trip a year is not a treadmill, but cap it deliberately and revisit if it ever starts wanting to be more.

6.6 Firefly Conservation Commitment

Added 27 May 2026 in response to Rieko's note that real fireflies are disappearing because they need clean water, dark skies, and healthy habitat, and that some scientists describe the current cohort as the last generation to reliably witness them in many regions.

The Kokoro Mirror app's Daily Light + Firefly Trove mechanic (see [context/pillar/app.md](#) Section 8) makes the firefly the central iconography of Auwa's daily practice. Each user collects fireflies they noticed in their own day; each captured firefly is a

small act of preservation in the user's life. The commitment extends that preservation outward into the world.

RE-ANCHORED 5 August 2026. The commitment was written against app subscription revenue, which no longer exists. It matters to Rieko personally and should survive the pivot, so it re-anchors to what Auwa actually sells: **Auwa commits five percent of Store revenue — figures, collab editions, prints and paper goods — to firefly habitat conservation, from the first sale, not contingent on profitability.** Books are excluded only if a publisher deal makes the accounting impractical; on self-published sales they are included.

The Daily Light + Firefly Trove mechanic that originally motivated this lives in the parked app, so the in-product surfaces below no longer apply. The firefly stays in the brand through Rieko's illustration work and through the commitment itself, and it remains a genuine differentiator: a competitor can copy a figure; a real conservation programme with named partners and annual impact reporting is harder to fake.

(Original wording, retained for reference: Auwa commits five percent of every subscription to firefly habitat conservation, from the first paid subscriber, not contingent on profitability.)

Partners. Identified by Rieko's Japan network. Initial shortlist:

- Tatsuno Firefly Conservation Society (Nagano)
- Moriyama Hotaru Festival conservation arm (Shiga)
- Itoshima Hotaru Network (Fukuoka)
- Xerces Society for Invertebrate Conservation (US / international)

Final partner selection during Stage 6 of the app build (content engine + friends release). Two partners maximum at launch to keep relationships substantive; expand later as revenue allows.

Communication. Three surfaces:

- One sentence on the App Store description and auwa.life/app: *Five percent of every Auwa subscription supports firefly habitat conservation in Japan and globally.*
- A small line in Settings: *Your subscription has supported firefly conservation. Read our annual impact report.*
- An annual impact email and shareable PDF: *This year, Auwa subscribers funded £X for firefly habitat restoration in [places]. Photos and project details inside.*

Why this is also business strategy. A weekend-built Claude-wrapper competitor can copy the app's UI. It cannot easily ship a real conservation programme with named partners and annual impact reporting. The commitment is part of Auwa's non-substitutable moat (see Section

15). It is also a credible signal to the audience we want (Kinfolk-readers, Japan-curious, design-conscious, values-aligned): they expect brands they invest in to put values into practice.

Financial model (revised). Five percent of Store revenue. At the Year 1 expected case that is a few hundred pounds; at a Year 2 store doing £60-80K it is £3-4K, which is meaningful to a small Japanese conservation group. Gross margin on Auwa-owned goods is 60-80%, so five percent leaves the unit economics healthy. Start with one partner, not two, until the numbers justify more.

6.7 Year 2+ Vision (Earned by Year 1 Results)

Revised 5 Aug 2026. Everything that depended on the app is retired rather than deferred: the Hotel Digital EQ Experience, the white-label EQ platform for hospitals and clinics, EQ corporate programmes, and any subscription community tier. Those were app-derived B2B lines and they go with it. What replaces them is character-IP-derived.

- **Character licensing.** The endgame, and the most passive revenue Auwa can have. Moomin is the model: an illustrated character licensed into goods, cafés and craft collaborations, ultimately far bigger abroad than at home. Requires the character to be known first, which is why publishing comes first.
- **Art-toy licensing (Pop Mart, Medicom and similar) — a 2028 conversation, assessed 12 Aug 2026.** The key finding is that **the book logic does not transfer, it inverts**. Self-publishing first damages the publisher route because a weak sales history is evidence against you in an editor's room. An art-toy licensor works the opposite way: they do not sign unknown characters off a deck, and prior sell-through, a waitlist and secondary-market prices *are* the pitch (Labubu was Kasing Lung's existing character with an existing following before Pop Mart). **So self-releasing figure editions builds the asset rather than burning it.** Run the editions exactly as planned. Two cautions. Pop Mart specifically may be the wrong partner: blind box, £12-15, mass production, trend-driven, which sits badly against hand-finished, numbered, never reissued and made in Japan, and makes the craft collab and museum-exhibition route harder. Medicom, How2Work, Unbox Industries or a Japanese soft-vinyl maker are much closer in register. **And the thing that would actually kill this option is a publishing contract retaining merchandising rights** — see [context/pillar/book.md](#), where the carve-out is already flagged as non-negotiable. Costless things to do now: keep the master form and 3D file wholly owned and unencumbered, grant no manufacturer exclusivity, number and document every edition (provenance is part of what a licensor buys), and keep clean sell-through records. Class 28 already covers collectible figures, art toys and blind box toys.

- **Exhibition: an Auwa × Japanese craft show.** London Craft Week or a foundation space first, Japan House as the year four or five destination. Grant-fundable. See 6.2a.
 - **72 Seasons of Auwa print series.** The full set as a collected edition or annual calendar, built from work Rieko already produces.
 - **Further figure editions and collab drops.** One or two a year at a leisurely cadence.
 - **Books 3 and 4,** and physical first editions of the earlier books.
 - **Seasonal Journeys** opened to paying guests after the 2027 pilot.
 - **London pop-up workshops** (ikebana, sashiko, a maker demonstration) — capital-light, Niwaki's Chiltern Street programme is the template.
 - **Auwa paper goods and lifestyle range,** kept small and design-led.
-

7. Market

Market landscape: Auwa sits at the intersection of several growing markets: AI wellness (~\$9.45B in 2026, projected \$18B by 2031), Japanese cultural exports (anime market \$37.7B, tourism 42.7M visitors in 2025), the premium craft/design economy, and the broader lifestyle editorial space. No single market size captures Auwa because no brand currently assembles all these elements under one roof.

Target audience (revised Aug 2026): Design-conscious, culturally curious people drawn to Japanese aesthetics, philosophy, and craft. They value meaning over metrics, intention over convenience, and quality over quantity. They read Kinfolk and Monocle, appreciate Aesop's retail experience, follow Studio Ghibli, and are more likely to buy one handmade knife than a drawer full of disposable ones.

Three distinct entry points now, and they are not the same person:

- **Story readers** — drawn in by the character and the illustration. Buy books, prints, paper goods. The largest and most important group, because everything else depends on the character being loved.
- **Object collectors** — art-toy and design-object buyers, overlapping heavily with Bearbrick, KAWS and Sonny Angel audiences. Buy figures and artist collab editions. Reachable through collaborators' audiences, which is the point of the artist line.
- **Japan-interested readers** — arrive through the journal and photography. Slower to convert to purchase, but they are the audience for journeys, and the reason the editorial pillar earns its place.

(Retired: the wellness-app audience, which the app was aimed at.)

Uncopyable advantages ("The Authenticity Moat") — revised Aug 2026:

- Rieko's decade of creation + a series of completed illustrated stories
 - Japanese cultural authenticity (Kansai-born, Japanese-educated, native Japanese speaker) — which since the pivot is not a positioning claim but the operational engine, because every maker, gallery and institution conversation runs through Rieko in Japanese
 - Yaoyorozu no Kami embedded by a Japanese creator who grew up within the philosophy
 - The character and its master form, and the blank-canvas mechanic that makes a maker's own Kokoro the thing revealed
 - 72 micro-seasons as perpetual content rhythm (refreshing every 5 days), which is also a product
 - Hand-illustrated character variants
 - Direct Japanese maker relationships, once built — slow to acquire and therefore slow to copy
 - Editorial depth (Tom's published Japan photography, 17M+ Unsplash views)
 - Tom's operational precedent selling Japanese design objects to Western buyers (2005-2007), including distributing KAWS's first international releases — which is directly the art-toy collaboration world the new plan sits in
 - The Yamato emotional framework (dormant with the app, still owned)
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8. Go-To-Market Strategy

The Sequence: Brand First, Products Second

The website establishes the brand. Instagram builds the audience. The app and store launch into an audience that already understands what Auwa is. This is the opposite of building in a vacuum and hoping people find you.

The core website (auwa.life) comes first. A beautiful, Kinfolk-inspired hub that introduces the brand philosophy, houses the journal, teases the app and store, and gives Instagram posts somewhere to point to. Typography-led, photography-rich, serene. This is the brand's home — the thing that makes Auwa feel real and credible before a single product ships. Built with Claude Code in a few focused days using the existing Next.js foundation.

Social Strategy: Instagram First

Single-platform focus until 5K followers. Instagram is where the audience lives — design-conscious, Japan-interested, culturally curious. TikTok skews younger and more fleeting. YouTube is for depth content later. One strong Instagram account looks intentional; scattered small accounts look amateur. Expand to TikTok reposts and YouTube after 5K.

See `context/marketing/instagram.md` for detailed IG strategy, specs, content pillars, and growth plan.

Phase 1: Brand Foundation (Weeks 1-6)

Parallel tracks:

- **Core website:** Build `auwa.life` — brand home, journal section with first editorial pieces, app teaser, store teaser, email capture. Kinfolk-level design quality. Typography-forward, photography-rich, dark aesthetic.
- **Instagram:** Daily posting from vault content (Japan photography, Rieko's illustrations, Auwa animations, Fin DAC stencil session). Target: 700 → 2,000+ followers.
- **First journal articles:** 3-5 editorial pieces using existing Japan photography. Atmospheric travel essays, seasonal reflections. Start building SEO presence.
- **Creative direction:** Lock illustration refresh, character variants, brand feel.

Success metrics (Week 6): Website live and beautiful. 3+ journal articles published. 1,000+ IG followers. 200+ email signups. Brand feels coherent and premium across website and social.

Phase 2 REPLACED (Aug 2026): Ship the objects (Aug 2026 - early 2027)

The original Phase 2 was the app build and soft launch. Retired.

Phase 1's brand foundation is done: the site is live and award-recognised, the Instagram is at 2,667, articles are published. What has never happened is **shipping anything a person can buy**. Zero revenue to date, and two finished books sitting unreleased, which is the worst possible state for an asset to be in. Phase 2 is therefore about getting objects into the world.

- **Books off print test, route decided** (publisher first, POD fallback), releasing as a two-book set.
- **Figure finished and dropped:** bio-filament, finish, packaging, price. First edition 25-50 units.
- **Shopify shelf live** with Auwa-owned goods only.
- **Fin DAC collab opened**, producing the photograph the whole collab programme is pitched with.

- **Journal back to ~1/month**, weighted toward makers and places.
- **Email capture continues:** the Quiet Letter and the Meta lead ads, which were already working (day-1 leads at £0.94, well under the £2 gate).
- **Instagram continues** on one account: 72-seasons cadence, character animation, and now product teasers and reveals.

Success metrics: books published or a publisher deal in progress; first figure edition sold through at 70%+; Fin DAC piece shipped and photographed; first revenue of any kind on the board; subscribers meaningfully above the current ~100.

Decision gate on the figure: below 30% sell-through, pause physical and reassess pricing or audience before committing to edition two.

Phase 3: Open Japan (2027)

Craftsman outreach opens once the books are printed, because the printed book is the calling card. Rieko writes in Japanese, offering a story first and commerce never in the first conversation. Target two or three makers, not twenty. First craft collab commissioned, kokeshi or daruma first. Journal weighted to those relationships. One Japan trip carrying craftsman meetings, photography, journey recon and collab conversations together. Seasonal Journeys piloted by Tom and Rieko alone. Second figure edition. YouTube opens only if the Shigefusa film exists.

Phase 4: Institution (2028+)

Earned by results. Enough craft pieces to exhibit. London Craft Week or a foundation show with a UK-Japan grant behind it. Press and guest articles. Journeys open to paying guests. Character licensing conversations. Japan House as the year four or five destination.

9. Content Engine

Instagram content pillars:

1. **Kokoro Reveal** — Auwa illustrations paired with poetic reflections. The signature format. Shareable, beautiful, brand-building.
2. **Seasonal Living** — Japan photography tied to the rhythm of the year. Atmospheric, contemplative. Bridges to journal articles.

3. **Behind the Kokoro** — Rieko's illustration process, craftsman workshops, creative decisions. Human, process-driven.
4. **Japanese Wisdom** — Philosophy in practice. Micro-seasons, awareness concepts, quotes. Carousels and Reels.

72 micro-seasons calendar provides an always-on content rhythm refreshing every 5 days. Posts on Instagram 4-5 times per week.

Existing content vault (ready to deploy): 15+ years of Japan photography (Tom's Japan photography has amassed 17M+ views on Unsplash and been used by Condé Nast Traveler, Vogue, World Economic Forum, Travel + Leisure, TimeOut, and Culture Trip), Rieko's illustrations and animations, Fin DAC Auwa stencil session, craftsman photography from Monolise research trips, Auwa story scenes (10+ polished scenes usable now).

YouTube (Phase 2-3): Long-form craftsman videos (ASMR-style making processes), Japan travel content, philosophy deep-dives, interviews. Bi-weekly uploads once established.

10. Customer Acquisition

Channels

- **Organic Instagram:** The primary growth engine. 72 micro-seasons content rhythm, illustration reveals, Japan photography, craftsman spotlights, Auwa animation Reels. Shareable Kokoro cards from the app as a zero-cost viral mechanic.
- **Paid Instagram (£2,000 Year 1):** £15-25/day in bursts on best-performing Reels. Split: 60% follower growth/awareness, 30% email capture/waitlist, 10% retargeting. Expected: 1,500-3,000 quality followers + 300-800 email signups.
- **SEO via Journal:** In 2026, traditional search has evolved — Google's AI Overviews now summarise results directly, reducing click-through for generic queries. But long-tail, specific, expertise-driven content still drives organic traffic. Auwa's journal articles target keywords the brand naturally owns: specific Japanese crafts, artisan traditions, onsen culture, seasonal philosophy, Japan travel through a philosophical lens. These are niche topics where genuine experience (Tom's 15+ years of Japan photography, Rieko's cultural authenticity) signals authority that AI search tools (Google, Perplexity, ChatGPT) surface and cite. Each article serves dual purposes: brand depth for existing audience + discovery for new visitors. SEO compounds over time — articles published in Month 1 are still driving traffic in Month 12.

- **Collaborations:** Fin DAC (96K IG followers, existing Auwa stencil — warm lead). Japanese culture accounts, illustration accounts, design/philosophy accounts via Instagram's native collab post feature.
- **Podcast/press outreach (after 5K IG):** Wellness, Japan culture, design podcasts. Press: Dezeen, It's Nice That, Monocle, The Verge.

Year 1 marketing budget: ~£3,000-4,000 (Instagram-focused spend is more efficient than multi-platform).

Conversion Model (revised Aug 2026, to Jan 2027)

The old model was app-funnel shaped (free users → paid subscribers) and is retired. Baseline at 5 Aug 2026: 2,667 Instagram followers, ~100 subscribers, £0 revenue.

Metric	Conservative	Expected	Optimistic
Instagram followers	4,000	6,000	8,000
Email subscribers	600	1,200	2,000
Monthly journal visitors (SEO)	500	2,000	5,000
Figure edition sell-through	30%	70%	sold out + waitlist
Books published	POD live	POD live + publisher talks	publisher deal signed
Collab pieces shipped	1 (Fin DAC)	2-3	4+ incl. one Japanese artist

11. Revenue Model & Financial Projections

Auwa generates revenue from objects it owns. More Air client work funds the founders separately, and the household already needs no income from Auwa (see the personal finance project) — so Auwa revenue is reinvested into growth, and its real job is the dignity of the venture paying its own way rather than financial permission to stop client work.

Revenue Streams by Pillar

Revised 5 Aug 2026. App subscription revenue is removed. Everything below is object revenue at 60-80% margin, plus one high-margin experience line from 2027.

Story (auwa.life/book): Book sales. POD at £28-35 trade, signed first edition at £45-60. If a publisher deal lands the economics change entirely (advance plus royalty, much lower per-unit, vastly higher reach) — and reach is what the business actually needs, so that trade is worth making.

Store (auwa.life/store): Auwa-owned goods (figures, prints, paper goods, the 72-seasons set) at 60-80% margin, plus collaboration editions. Artist collabs are the recurring commercial line; craft collabs are prestige and should not be modelled as meaningful revenue. Tom's operational precedent: a niche Japanese vinyl figure store in 2004-2007 generated ~£1,500/month profit with a fraction of today's audience and tools.

Journal (auwa.life/journal): Not a revenue stream. Its value is brand authority, SEO, and being the calling card for maker relationships. Later potential: sponsored content from aligned brands.

Seasonal Journeys (from 2027): £3-4K per person, five people, once a year. £15-20K at healthy margin, and it produces a year of editorial. Not in Year 1.

Character licensing (Year 3+): The most passive line available and the one the whole plan is quietly building toward. Nothing to model yet.

Year 1 Revenue (to April 2027)

Stream	Conservative	Expected	Optimistic
Books (POD; publisher advance not modelled)	£500	£2,000	£5,000
Auwa figures (autumn 2026 drop, 25-50 units at £140-180)	£2,000	£5,000	£8,000
Prints + paper goods + 72-seasons set	£500	£2,000	£5,000
Collab editions (Fin DAC first, then 1-2 more)	£1,000	£4,000	£10,000
Auwa Total	£4,000	£13,000	£28,000

Lower headline than the pre-pivot projection, and deliberately so: the app's £3.5K expected line is gone, and the figure edition is cut from ~100 units to 25-50 to keep the physical workload sane. What the numbers do not show is that every line here is now a durable good at 60-80% margin, with no inventory risk on anyone else's stock, and no subscription base to service. **Year 1 remains an investment year.** The point of it is not the revenue, it is getting objects into the world and proving each line.

Costs are broadly unchanged (see below), except that API and app hosting fall away and figure production and print costs rise, roughly cancelling out. The £15,000 More Air envelope authorised on 8 July 2026 still governs and still covers the Madrid filing, figure production, book printing and the paid-social lane.

Costs

Monthly: £660-1,065 (API, hosting, tools, marketing, virtual office). One-time: £4,290-5,290 (trademark, figure production, seeding, domains). Year 1 total: ~£12,000-18,000.

Year 1 Summary

Scenario	Revenue	Costs	Net
Conservative	£1,000	£14,000	-£13,000
Expected	£6,500	£16,000	-£9,500
Optimistic	£21,000	£18,000	+£3,000

Year 1 is an investment year funded by More Air client work. Self-sustaining threshold: ~100-150 paid app subscribers + modest store sales covers monthly operating costs.

Year 2 (Contingent on Traction)

Revised 5 Aug 2026. App subscriptions, craftsman commission and hotel B2B all removed. The realistic Year 2 range is much lower than the old plan claimed, and it is worth being honest that the old £107-378K range was carried almost entirely by two lines that no longer exist.

Stream	Target
Books (POD + first edition; or publisher royalties)	£5,000-25,000
Auwa figures (2-3 editions)	£10,000-30,000

Collab editions (artist line, 3-4 drops)	£8,000-25,000
Prints, paper goods, 72-seasons set	£4,000-15,000
Seasonal Journey (one trip, if piloted successfully)	£0-20,000
Journal sponsored/affiliate (if validated)	£0-5,000
Year 2 Range	£27,000-120,000

This lands squarely on the **£20-60K at a leisurely pace** that Tom and Rieko actually said they want (the lifestyle-design principle agreed 15 July 2026), rather than on a growth curve neither of them wants to service. That is a feature of the pivot, not a shortfall against it. The old plan's headline was larger and structurally incompatible with a three-to-four-day week and two months a year in Japan.

12. Corporate & Legal Structure

Full details in `context/business/structure.md` (Auwa-Structure.pdf).
Summary below.

Auwa Limited (Co. 17033727) owns all IP. Dormant. Rieko + Tom 50/50. Licenses to More Air. **More Air Limited** (Co. 7051794) operates Auwa. Active since 2009. Receives revenue, pays expenses.

Trademarks (UK IPO):

- Word mark "Auwa": UK00004341028 (Classes 9, 16, 20, 41, in advertisement phase) + UK00004373944 (Classes 25, 28, 35, filed 16 April 2026)
- Design mark (Auwa character): UK00004373930 (Classes 20, 28, filed 16 April 2026)
- International (Madrid Protocol): Japan, USA, EU planned by August 2026

Domains: auwa.life (primary), auwa.app, auwa.world, auwa.store + .com equivalents. 11 domains total. **Social:** @auwalife across most platforms, @auwa.life on TikTok and Bluesky, @auwa on LinkedIn. See `context/marketing/social.md` for the full account map. **Email:** hello@auwa.life

13. Team

The Creator + Producer Model

Following the traditional Japanese ukiyo-e model (artist + publisher as equal partnership). Tsutaya Juzaburo is the historical precedent.

Rieko Maeda, Creator (Eshi): Japanese-born illustrator from Kansai, also known by her artist name Eko. Creator of the Auwa universe (2015-2025). Native Japanese speaker. 20+ years design and illustration. (Legal name: Rieko Vining.) Year 1 (revised Aug 2026): the books finished and out, seasonal content at the 72-season cadence, figure design and the blank/master form for collabs, creative direction, and **all Japanese-language outreach to artists, makers, galleries and institutions** — which since the pivot is the pillar the entire Japan practice runs on rather than a side task.

Tom Vining, Producer (Hanmoto): Design technologist and brand strategist. 20+ years experience (Nokia, Apple, Sky). Built and operated a Japanese multi-merchant platform (2005-2007) selling Japanese design objects to Western buyers — including distributing KAWS's first international releases. Published photographer whose Japan work has 17M+ views on Unsplash and has been used by Condé Nast Traveler, Vogue, World Economic Forum, Travel + Leisure, TimeOut, and Culture Trip. Expert in AI-native workflows. Year 1 (revised Aug 2026): publishing route, figure production and packaging, the Shopify shelf, brand, photography, business development, financials, marketing, project oversight. (App design and build: delivered, now parked.)

Capacity: Tuesday-Friday (3-4 day week, 10am-6pm). Auwa gets 60%, More Air 25%, ventures 10%. Shifts toward Auwa as revenue grows. No work Monday.

AI tools: Claude, Cursor, Suno, vo. Learning curve built into timeline.

Project Management: Notion. Weekly rhythm. Simple Kanban. Fortnightly reviews.

14. Risk Analysis

Revised 5 Aug 2026. App-specific risks retired with the app.

Risk	Pillar	Likelihood	Mitigation
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Craft work keeps beating shipping	All	High	The single realest risk, evidenced twice already: the app was built and never released, and two finished books have sat unreleased for months. Everything in the current plan is gated on <i>getting an object out</i> . Treat "finished but unreleased" as the worst state an asset can be in.
Character never becomes known	Story	High	The whole plan depends on it. Publishing properly (publisher route tried first) is the main lever; collab photographs, exhibition route and press are the others.
Craftsman outreach yields nothing	Store	Medium	Expected, at first. Approach with a printed book and a story offered as a gift, never a commercial ask. Target mid-career and successor makers, not masters with waiting lists. Measure on being welcome back, not on yesses.
Collab audience mismatch (nobody buys a craft piece)	Store	High, and accepted	Craft collabs are not modelled as revenue. The maker manufactures, holds and sells domestically to their own trusting

			customers; Auwa takes a small Western allocation and carries no inventory risk. The return is authority, editorial and exhibitability.
Figures don't sell	Store	Medium	First edition cut to 25-50 to cap exposure. Pre-orders and lottery seeding. Below 30% sell-through, pause physical and reassess.
Physical workload overwhelms two people	Store	Medium	Small editions, POD wherever possible, collaborators hold their own stock, no third-party inventory. If the making stops being enjoyable, the edition is too big.
Publisher route stalls and wastes months	Story	Medium	IngramSpark POD is executable at any time and requires no permission. Set a decision date rather than waiting open-endedly.
Journeys regulatory exposure	Journeys	Medium	Package Travel Regulations 2018 — resolve via a licensed operator partner or by selling a guided experience only, before any deposit is taken. See 6.5.
Journal doesn't drive traffic	Journal	Low impact now	Its main job is now the maker calling card, not SEO. Even zero search

			traffic leaves it doing its primary work.
Brand reads as a shop with a mascot	All	Medium	Character leads, goods follow, never the reverse. No white-label, no curated resale, no apparel range.
Client work crowds out Auwa	All	Low now	Auwa is near-exclusive focus for the rest of 2026 (decision 8 Jul 2026).
Yen strengthens sharply	Store	Low	Minimal exposure now — Auwa holds no Japanese stock. Only affects collab wholesale pricing.

(Retired: app resonance, AI reflection quality, AI app commoditisation, API costs, marketplace logistics, and "new to shipping software.")

15. AI Disruption & Market Timing

Superseded in part, 5 Aug 2026. This section was written to answer "is now the right time to launch an app like this." The app is parked, so the app-specific argument is moot. Two things in it survive and are now more load-bearing than before, and they are worth stating up front before the original text.

First, the AI-fatigue tailwind is now the whole thesis rather than a supporting argument. As feeds fill with generated text and images, the counter-movement toward human-made, slow, ritual and craft is exactly what Auwa now sells: Rieko's illustrations, a printed book, a hand-finished figure, a lacquered object made by a named maker in Japan. The pivot moved Auwa *further* from the commoditised end of the market, not closer to it. The section below argued the app was insulated from AI disruption; the objects are simply not in its path at all.

Second, Tom's own scepticism is a legitimate market signal, not a failure of nerve. He asked whether he would use an emotional-reflection app in a world where he already has

general-purpose AI, and concluded he would not. That is a first-person read from exactly the technically fluent segment such an app has to win first, and it is worth more than any market-size projection. Recorded here so it does not get argued away later.

What does not survive: the claim that build cost collapsing makes app-building a good bet. It cuts both ways — the same collapse means any indie builder can ship a similar app in a weekend, which was one of Tom's stated reasons for walking away. Cheap to build is not the same as worth building.

Original text, 27 May 2026, retained below for reference.

The "SaaS is being crushed by AI" narrative is real but applies to a different category of product than Auwa. Three things are getting conflated in the discourse and they have different risk profiles. This section names where Auwa sits in the landscape and why now is a structurally good time to launch.

What "AI disrupting apps" actually means

The disruption is happening in single-purpose B2B productivity tools with thin AI wrappers. Grammarly losing share to ChatGPT. Jasper losing share to ChatGPT. Standalone summarisation, translation, scheduling, and meeting-notes apps being absorbed into general-purpose LLM interfaces. The pattern: a product that does one workflow task with a thin wrapper around technology that has commoditised gets squeezed when the underlying technology becomes free.

Defensible B2B SaaS now needs deep workflow integration, proprietary data, network effects, or a hard-to-replicate vertical specialisation. Generic tools die. Notion, Linear, Figma are fine. Grammarly Premium is in trouble. Auwa is not in this category.

Where consumer apps actually stand

Consumer apps with strong identity, content, or community are growing during the AI boom, not shrinking. Recent data points:

- **Finch.** Launched 2021, grew to \$30M ARR and 2M daily users entirely during the AI boom years. No VC. Character plus content plus practice. Not touched by AI disruption.
- **Calm.** ~\$250M revenue, still expanding. Tamara's voice reading sleep stories, rain sounds, guided meditations. Human-attended content, not replaceable by a chatbot.
- **Headspace.** \$200M+ revenue. Same shape: brand, voice, human-attended content.

- **BeReal, Lapse, Locket.** Grew through AI peak by leaning into aesthetic, ritual, friend-graph identity.
- **Letterboxd, Goodreads, Strava, Duolingo.** Strong identity, community, ritual. Continuing growth.

The pattern: apps where the *content is the product* (a story, a character, a voice, a ritual, a community) are not being replaced by AI agents. Apps where the *workflow is the product* are.

The agentic-future argument

The strong version of the disruption narrative says that in five years you talk to an agent and it handles all workflows that today require opening twenty apps. Plausible for many categories. Implausible for Auwa, for a structural reason worth naming.

Awareness is inherently user-present. You cannot delegate noticing what you feel to an agent. An agent that said "I have noticed you are feeling Aware today, here is what you should do about it" would be the exact thing Auwa is built to refuse. The user wants their own awareness, not a delegated one. The same logic applies to meditation, journaling, art-making, prayer, and any first-person ritual.

Apps that survive agentification are the ones whose value comes from being present to them. Apps whose value comes from completing a task are the ones being absorbed. Auwa, Finch, Calm, Headspace, Strava, Duolingo, BeReal, Letterboxd are all in the first category.

Why AI is a tailwind for Auwa specifically

Three real tailwinds.

First, AI fatigue is a real and growing consumer signal. As feeds fill with AI-generated text and images, there is a measurable counter-movement toward human-made, slow, ritual, craft. Auwa is exactly this: Rieko's illustrations, Japanese philosophy, hand-pressed paper print, slow daily practice. The brand reads as a counterweight to AI noise, which is increasingly what people are paying for.

Second, build cost has collapsed. Auwa being built by two people in six weeks is only possible because of AI tooling. Three years ago this needed a team of five to ten people and a year. The tooling shift means the same craft can be shipped much faster and at much lower capital risk. We are beneficiaries of the disruption, not victims of it.

Third, the wellness and Japan-curiosity markets are both expanding. Wellness apps grew roughly 10% in 2025. Japan inbound tourism hit a record. Ikigai and philosophy books continue

selling millions. The structural conditions are favourable independent of AI.

Where AI is genuinely a threat, and the defence

The real risk is not AI agents replacing Auwa. It is generic AI tools commoditising poorly-positioned competitors that copy Auwa's surface. Anyone can build a generic mood tracker with a Claude wrapper in a weekend. If Auwa positions itself as "AI-powered emotional reflection," it will get commoditised within months by indie builders shipping the same thing.

The defence is what we have already chosen: brand, voice, character, philosophy, craft, the physical artefacts, and (added 27 May 2026) the firefly conservation commitment. The reflection library written in Rieko's voice direction, the five Yamato character variants, the printed Kokoro portrait, the Firefly Year book, the curated craftsman store, the journal, the illustrated book, and a real conservation programme with named partners and annual impact reporting. These are non-substitutable. A Claude wrapper cannot ship them, and the conservation programme in particular cannot be cloned in a weekend.

Auwa's positioning explicitly avoids the AI-tool framing in marketing. The app does use Claude Haiku for classification (one cheap call per revelation), but the user-facing identity is Japanese philosophy, illustrated by a Japanese artist, written in a specific voice, anchored in a ten-year creative project. That positioning is durable. A pivot to "AI-powered" anything would invite the disruption we are otherwise insulated from.

The Senshin feature (see [context/pillar/app.md](#) Section 9) is also part of this moat. The combination of end-to-end encryption for the user's most sensitive content, a paper-first principle that contradicts the standard *more engagement equals more revenue* design, a culturally accurate framing in the chōzubachi temple-purification tradition, a thoughtful always-available crisis link without detection or intervention, and a free-forever commitment for mental-health-adjacent material is hard to replicate by a Claude-wrapper competitor. Each principled choice on its own is buildable; the combination of all of them with the conservation commitment, the no-AI-generated-content commitment, and the Rieko-anchored illustration system is what compounds into a defensible position.

The honest summary

Apps as a category are bifurcating. The half being disrupted is single-purpose workflow tools with thin AI wrappers. The half not being disrupted is identity-and-content products with brand, voice, community, ritual, and human craft. Auwa is firmly in the second half. The wellness category specifically has not been touched by AI disruption and shows no sign of being.

Auwa's real risks are not AI disruption. They are craft quality (does the writing actually land), distribution (Instagram audience growth toward 5K+), and unit economics at low scale (£6.99/month against a small launch user base). These are real risks but they are the normal risks of launching a consumer brand. None of them are accelerated by the AI shift; if anything the AI shift makes the craft and identity bets more valuable.

Market timing is favourable. The build window is open.

16. Strategic Priorities (from 5 August 2026)

Replaces the March 2026 twelve-week list, which was website-and-app shaped and is now fully delivered or retired.

1. **Pay WIPO before 15 August.** Must come from More Air. Nothing else moves until it is done. Miss it and the international trademark protection already applied for is lost.
2. **Books off print test and a route decided.** Publisher first with Colin Midson's view as the decisive input; IngramSpark POD as the always-available fallback. Release Books 1 and 2 as a set. This is the highest-leverage act available because everything downstream needs the character to be known.
3. **Figure finished and dropped.** Bio-filament testing, finish, packaging, price. First edition 25-50 units, hand-finished, numbered, signed.
4. **Simple Shopify shelf** for Auwa-owned goods only.
5. **Fin DAC collab opened this autumn.** Warm, easy, and it produces the photograph that every subsequent collab is pitched with.
6. **Journal back to ~1 article/month,** weighted toward makers and places, because it is now the calling card for Japanese outreach.
7. **Craftsman outreach opens once the books are printed.** Rieko, in Japanese, offering a story and nothing else. Two or three makers, not twenty. Kokeshi and daruma first.
8. ~~Website to three doors.~~ **DONE 5 Aug 2026** — and went further, removing the count entirely rather than reducing it. See CLAUDE.md CURRENT PHASE item 8 for the full list of what shipped.
9. **Keep the capture engine running.** The Quiet Letter, the Meta lead ads (converting at under £1 a lead, well under the £2 gate), and one Instagram account with product reveals added.

Not on the list, deliberately: app work of any kind, a marketplace, buying craftsman stock, white-label goods, apparel, a second social account, and the trademark class 39 question (flagged

for later, must not disturb the Madrid filing now).

The trademark portfolio already anticipated this pivot. Classes 16 (books, printed matter, illustrations), 20 (decorative objects, figurines), 25 (clothing), 28 (collectible figures, art toys, designer toys), 35 (online retail) and 41 (publishing, exhibitions) cover the entire new plan, including exhibitions and the collab editions. Class 9 (software) is retained for a possible return to the app. Nothing about the pivot requires a new filing.

17. Future Vision

Rewritten 5 Aug 2026.

As AI accelerates and automates more of life's cognitive tasks, the things that hold value are the ones made by human hands with a story behind them. Auwa is designed for this future, and the pivot moved it further into that position rather than away from it.

The brand scales with the character at the centre and the goods following. The books become known, first through a set of two and eventually four. The character becomes recognisable enough that a Japanese maker is pleased rather than puzzled to interpret it. The store becomes a small, considered shelf of Auwa-made and Auwa-commissioned objects that people collect rather than consume. The journal becomes a respected editorial voice in the Japanese culture and design space, and the reason makers take the call.

The endgame is licensing, and Moomin is the map. Tove Jansson's illustrated world went books → known character → licensed goods → craft collaborations → shops and cafés, and ended up larger in Japan than in Finland. That arc is the most passive, most durable, most travel-compatible business available to a two-person studio, and every step in the current plan is a step along it. It requires exactly one thing that Auwa does not yet have: a character people know. Which is why publishing the books properly outranks everything.

The exhibition is the bridge. An illustrated character interpreted by Japanese craft masters is programmable by cultural institutions in a way that a character brand with a shop never is. That route buys reach and legitimacy that no amount of paid social can, and it is grant-fundable. 2028 or later, but it is the reason to start commissioning craft pieces now.

(Retired: the agentic-web vision, which depended on the app.)

Key Contacts

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- Contact: hello@auwa.life
- Social: @auwalife (most platforms) | @auwa.life (TikTok, Bluesky) | @auwa (LinkedIn) — see `context/marketing/social.md`
- Companies House: Auwa Ltd 17033727 | More Air Ltd 7051794
- Trademarks: UK00004341028 (word mark, advertisement phase) | UK00004373944 (word mark, filed) | UK00004373930 (design mark, filed)

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